Beijing's moves also have revealed a new Chinese leadership, more willing than in the past to take bold steps and exercise their own outside options, especially with active support from major Western powers such as Britain and Germany. Their support not only boosts the AIIB's credit rating but also gives China international legitimacy. China's influence is growing, and U.S. allies are willing to withhold cooperation with the United States when they see potential gains and manageable risks elsewhere, despite Washington's clear preferences that they desist. This growing international reach of China also extends to the internationalization of the RMB and its inclusion as a reserve currency by the IMF, as well as its One Belt, One Road (OBOR) initiative, which, together with loans from Chinese state banks, the AIIB and NDB, are expected to contribute substantially to increasing investment in infrastructure and facilitating the movement of goods, services, and people across national borders. This is an outcome that also benefits China economically and potentially expands its regional influence.

China still accepts the basic rules of the existing order and appreciates the benefits that it accrues from acting multilaterally with the BRICS by promoting new mechanisms and institutions, to increase its influence—and by extension, the collective influence of the BRICS—on shaping the reform and operation of existing governance arrangements.[119] After working toward having a more equal voice and representation on its own, and with the BRICS collective "rise from within" strategy, China was finally rewarded in 2016 with the third-largest voting share in the new IMF reform package, roughly the same share as the second-ranking Japan, and senior positions in the Bretton Woods institutions. China, as a great power with immense financial resources, is also better positioned than other BRICS to exercise an exit option and engage in forum-shopping when it needs to satisfy its individual interests though another institutional setting.

In contrast, and possessing significantly lower levels of capabilities than China, the four other BRICS are incentivized to ride China's rise and exploit opportunities to tap into its immense financial reserves for their own investment priorities and loans when needed. Lesser states cannot expect that institutions—let alone loose clubs with few rules—will reliably bind hegemons. This means that the other BRICS have to skillfully manage their complex relations with Beijing, perhaps by providing China with concrete interests in seeing them prosper, such as what would result from joint business ventures or investments in one another's economies.